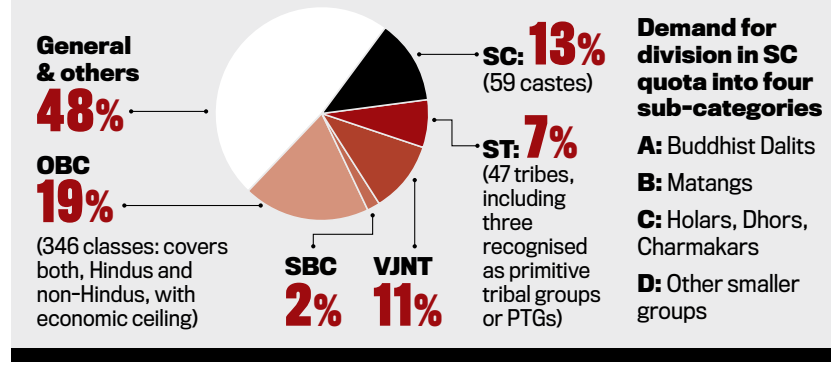
Fakira Ukarande, working president, Mumbai, Akhil Bharatiya Matang Sangh, said that they want the present 13 per cent SC quota to be divided into four sub-categories—A, B, C and D. He asked that the state government approve this demand in the budget session of the legislature and send it to the Union government for approval, failing which the community would intensify its protests.

Former minister and BJP leader Laxmanrao Dhobale, a Matang himself and head of the Bahujan Rayat Parishad, expresses sympathy for the Hindu Dalit cause. "There are around four to five numerically significant castes within the Hindu Dalit fold," he says. "While the Buddhist Dalits are estranged from them as they were not part of Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar's movement, caste Hindus, too, keep them away. As a result, Hindu Dalits lag in education and employment."

Elaborating on the theme further, Dhobale pointed out that while SCs formed around 13.2 million of Maharashtra's population, Buddhist Dalits added up to 6.5 million, followed by the Matangs at 4 million and Charmakars at 1.5 million. "While the benefits are meant for all the 13.2 million SCs, they are largely cornered by the 6.5 million," he alleged. Reiterating the demand for division of the SC category into four sub-categories, he said A could be for Buddhist Dalits, B for Matangs, C for the Charmakars, Dhors and Holars and D for the smaller Dalit groups.

Bifurcated quotas are nothing new, there is precedent in Maharashtra itself. The 30 per cent reservation for the other backward classes (OBCs), for example, is split into 19 per cent for the OBC category proper and 11 per cent for the Vimukta Jati and Nomadic Tribes. The last, in turn, is split into 3 per cent for VJs or denotified tribes and 2.5 per cent for the nomadic tribes category B, 3.5 per cent for the category C (Dhangar community) and 2 per cent for category D (the Vanjari community).

CASTE-BASED QUOTAS IN MAHARASHTRA



However, former minister Avinash Mahatekar, a Republican Party of India (RPI) leader, is not comfortable with the idea of bifurcated quotas. "The historical reasoning (behind the claim that Buddhist Dalits have secured most benefits under the SC category) must be examined," he says. He also seems to believe that the exposure to education and western, modern ideas that the Mahar community got as part of the armies of the East India Company and the British gave them a head start over other Dalit groups in terms of social mobility. "In comparison, other Dalit groups took time to adopt education," he says. "(Obviously) the community that educated itself first managed to get the benefit of reservations."

Sub-categorisation of SCs has been an idea toyed with before. In its report submitted to the Union government in May 2008, the Justice Usha Mehra Commission had recommended the sub-categorisation and de-sub-categorisation of SCs to aid the deprived classes among them. In Andhra Pradesh, groups such as the Madiga Reservation Porata Samiti (MRPS) have been seeking categorisation of SCs and demanding that the Union government introduce a bill for creating four sub-categories.

HINDU DALITS ALLEGE THAT THE BUDDHIST DALITS CORNER MOST OF THE 13 PER CENT QUOTA ALLOTTED TO THE SCs

What has been the historical position? In 1965, the report of the advisory committee on the revision of the lists of SCs and STs appointed by the Government of India's department of social security under Justice B.N. Lokur had noted: "It has been in evidence for some time now that a lion's share of the various benefits and concessions earmarked for SCs/STs is appropriated by the numerically larger and politically well-organised communities. The smaller and more backward communities have tended to get lost in democratic processes, though more deserving of special aid. Though there is no escape from the larger and politically more conscious groups asserting themselves in the political field, it appears to us that, in matters of planning and development, the distribution of benefits needs to be focused on the more backward and smaller groups on a selective basis." Since the equitable spread of life opportunities is the objective, that's unexceptionable. But will it be seen as a move to curtail the sway of more organised groups? The question, in the end, is always a political one. ■